

Founder's playbook: product, business & money gameplan

One working document to run with Frank - understand the product, demo it to veterans, decide how we get operational, and choose how we make money. Fill it in, check items off, and adjust as you go.

SAMPLE / PROTOTYPE. VetPath is a planning & education tool - not the VA, a law firm, or an accredited claims representative. All veteran-benefit content is sample/demo data to be verified with official sources. All dollar figures below are **illustrative assumptions to replace** - not projections or guarantees.

How to use this document: Work top to bottom. Parts 1–3 are the **product** (what we're building and how a veteran experiences it - use these to demo). Parts 4–5 are the **business** (how we get operational and make money - decide and adjust these together). Part 6 is where you **capture decisions and assign owners**. Anything with a ☐ box is an action to own; anything with a line is a blank to fill in.

Our recommendations at a glance - starting points to react to and adjust with Frank (details in Parts 4–5):

- **Structure:** start lean as an **LLC or public-benefit corp** for speed and B2B revenue; pursue grants via a fiscal sponsor now; add a 501(c)(3) arm later if grants become the core.
- **How we make money:** a **hybrid** - lead with **organization licenses** (VSOs, universities, employers) + **grants/sponsorship**, keep it **free for veterans**, and add optional premium convenience features in Year 2.
- **First real data:** build benefits for **your home state + Texas** first (large veteran population, well-known programs).
- **First pilot:** Frank's recurring veteran meeting.
- **Recommended Year-1 (lean) money target:** ~\$115k revenue vs. ~\$72k cost - see Part 5 (estimates to validate, not guarantees).

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Part 1 · The idea & who it's for

The idea. Veterans hear the same benefits information over and over at meetings and briefings, but walk away without a clear, personalized plan. VetPath turns a veteran's goals, life stage, state, age, and status into a **personalized 30/60/90-day gameplan** - prioritized benefits, concrete action steps, documents to gather, and links to the official sources to verify each one.

Who it's for (primary → secondary)

- **Primary:** service members transitioning out (0–24 months from separation).
- **Secondary:** veterans pursuing a job, education, home, or business; those navigating disability/health; those retiring; and spouses/family.

What makes it credible (and what it is not)

It is

A planning, education & navigation tool. It organizes, prioritizes, and points to official/accredited help.

It is not

The VA, a law firm, a claims agent, or an accredited rep. It never confirms eligibility or gives legal/medical/financial advice.

Hard product boundary: veterans, families, benefits, wellness, career, education, housing, entrepreneurship, retirement, and community only. No weapons, tactical/paramilitary/militia content, or political/extremist activity. Crisis resource always present: Veterans Crisis Line - dial 988, press 1.

Part 2 · What a veteran gets (sample gameplan)

This is the output of the app for one example veteran - use it to show Frank what a finished plan looks like. Content is sample/demo data.

Status: Transitioning (within 12 months)

Branch: Army

State: Texas

Service era: Post-9/11

Disability: 30–50% (sample)

Urgency: Next 1–3 months

Top goals: Transition out · Get a better job · Buy a home

Top priorities

1. Lock in VA health care and start a disability claim **before you separate.**
2. Build a job or education pipeline now - not after your last day.
3. Land a better job that values your service.
4. Use your VA home loan benefit the smart way.

30 / 60 / 90-day action plan

Next 30 days

- ☐ Complete TAP; safeguard DD-214 + medical records **HIGH**
- ☐ Start a VA disability claim (ask about Benefits Delivery at Discharge) **HIGH**
- ☐ Translate military experience into a civilian resume & LinkedIn **HIGH**
- ☐ Request VA home loan Certificate of Eligibility **HIGH**

Days 31–60

- ☐ Apply for VA health care; pick a facility near home **HIGH**
- ☐ Review your claim with a free accredited VSO **MEDIUM**
- ☐ Register with a Texas American Job Center / DOL VETS rep **MEDIUM**
- ☐ Get pre-approved with a VA-experienced lender **MEDIUM**

Days 61–90

- ☐ Have 3–5 job leads or an enrollment plan in motion **MEDIUM**
- ☐ Check Texas benefits (Hazlewood, property tax) - verify with the state **LOW**

Benefits & official sources to verify

VA health care - [va.gov/health-care](https://www.va.gov/health-care/) (https://www.va.gov/health-care/) · VA disability - [va.gov/disability](https://www.va.gov/disability/) (https://www.va.gov/disability/) (free accredited VSO help) · Employment - [dol.gov/agencies/vets](https://www.dol.gov/agencies/vets) (https://www.dol.gov/agencies/vets) · GI Bill - [va.gov/education](https://www.va.gov/education/) (https://www.va.gov/education/) · VA home loan - [va.gov/housing-assistance](https://www.va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans/) (https://www.va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans/) · State benefits - Texas Veterans Commission.

Why it matters: filing before separation can shorten the wait; early VA health-care enrollment protects access to care and mental-health support; the VA home loan can mean no down payment and no PMI.

Part 3 · Demo toolkit - build a plan with a veteran

Use this live with a veteran (or Frank). Goal: they leave with 3 goals chosen and at least three concrete next steps.

Worksheet - about you

Name

Age range

State of residence

Branch of service

Status (active / transitioning / veteran / retired / family)

Employment & housing situation

VA disability rating (optional)

How urgent does this feel?

Circle up to 3 goals

☐ Transition out of service

☐ Get a better job

☐ Use education benefits

☐ Buy a home

☐ Start a business

☐ Understand the disability process

☐ Prepare for retirement

☐ Move to a new state

☐ Get documents organized

☐ Find local veteran support

Your 30 / 60 / 90-day plan (write 1–2 steps per phase)

Next 30 days

Days 31–60

Days 61–90

Facilitator guide - running the session (~30 min)

Time	Do this
0–5	Frame it: "Not the VA telling you what you qualify for - a way to leave with a written plan you can act on."
5–12	Fill in the basics; circle up to 3 goals (most urgent, not everything).
12–22	Write 1–2 next-30-day steps per goal. Keep them small and specific.
22–28	Note documents to gather and the official source to verify each item.
28–30	Name the single first step for this week + who to call for free accredited help.

Discussion prompts

1. What's the one thing you wish someone had handed you when you left service?
2. Of your three goals, which one, if solved, makes the others easier?
3. What's stopped you from acting before - time, trust, or not knowing where to start?
4. Would a tool like VetPath help - and what would make you trust it (or not)?

Ground rules to say out loud: we don't confirm eligibility - official sources do; accredited VSO help is **free** (never pay for basic claims help); this is education and planning, not legal/medical/financial advice.

Part 4 · Business gameplan - getting operational

The sequence to go from prototype to a real, trusted product. Check items off and assign owners in Part 6.

Recommended focus: spend the first 90 days on three things only - (1) validate with ~10 veterans, (2) build real benefits data for your home state + Texas, and (3) land one pilot at Frank's meeting. Resist adding features until those are done.

Operational roadmap

Now → 30 days: validate & decide

- ☐ Review this prototype with Frank; capture reactions and edits.
- ☐ Interview 5–10 veterans (use the Part 3 worksheet) - what's missing, would they trust it, who should pay.
- ☐ Decide the working name, design direction, and lead monetization path (Part 5).
- ☐ Decide entity structure (see decision box below) and open a basic business setup.
- ☐ Line up one pilot partner (Frank's meeting or a local VSO chapter).

31–60 days: build the real core

- ☐ Build the **real benefits dataset for 1–2 states** with citations + "last-verified" dates (biggest effort - this is the credibility engine).
- ☐ Legal/compliance review of disclaimers; confirm we never charge for accreditation-required claims help.
- ☐ Add accounts + save/sync + printable PDF gameplan to the app.
- ☐ Build a simple "verify with an accredited VSO" directory/handoff.

61–90 days: pilot & measure

- ☐ Run the pilot at 1–2 veteran meetings; collect structured feedback.
- ☐ Track activation, plans completed, and "verified an official source" actions.
- ☐ Submit first revenue effort: a grant application or a partner license proposal.

6–12 months: expand

- ☐ Add states; add reminders/nudges; add spouse/caregiver mode + document vault.
- ☐ Sign 3–5 paying partners or secure sustaining grants; formalize data-update process.

Build tracks (who owns what)

Track	Key work	Owner
Product / UX	App, accounts, PDF export, accessibility for older vets	
Benefits data	Real, cited, per-state content + refresh cadence	
Legal / compliance	Disclaimers, accreditation boundary, privacy, entity	
Partnerships / GTM	VSOs, employers, universities, pilots, grants	
Ops / finance	Budget, tools, bookkeeping, fundraising	

Key decisions to make (circle one; note why)

Entity structure: ☐ Nonprofit 501(c)(3) ☐ For-profit LLC ☐ Public benefit corp ☐ Undecided

Recommended LLC or public-benefit corp now (move fast, earn B2B revenue); grants via a fiscal sponsor; a 501(c)(3) arm later if grants become core.

Your call / notes:

Lead monetization path: ☐ Balanced B2B2C ☐ Lean commercial ☐ Nonprofit/grant ☐ Hybrid

Recommended Hybrid - organization licenses + grants/sponsorship now (Paths A + C); premium convenience features in Year 2 (Path B). Veterans stay free.

Your call / notes:

First state(s) for real data:

Recommended Your home state + Texas first - large veteran populations and well-known programs (Hazlewood, property-tax exemptions).

Your call / notes:

Top risks & how we protect against them

Risk	Mitigation
Trust - feels like a scam / claim shark	Never charge for claims help; always point to free accredited VSOs; cite official sources.
Accuracy & liability - rules change by state	"Last-verified" dates; sample-data labeling until real; legal review of disclaimers.
Scope creep into advice	Education/navigation only; explicit non-advice language.
Data sensitivity (health, disability, finances)	Data minimization; encryption; never sell data; explicit consent.
Adoption by older veterans	High-readability UX; print option; in-person facilitation via meetings/VSOs.

Part 5 · Money gameplan - how we make money

Keep it free (or low-cost) for veterans; make money from organizations, grants, and sponsors that want to serve veterans. All figures below are **illustrative** - replace with your own assumptions.

Three revenue paths

Path A - Balanced, mission-first (B2B2C) Recommended base

Who pays: VSOs, employers with veteran-hiring, universities/veteran-services offices, workforce boards, foundations, ethical sponsors. **For:** a branded/licensed instance, privacy-safe aggregate analytics, co-branded content, priority support.

Veteran pays: nothing.

+ Highest trust, broadest reach. – Slower revenue; needs partnerships.

Path B - Lean commercial (SaaS)

Who pays: organizations on tiered SaaS (Starter/Pro/Enterprise), base-transition & employer contracts; optional premium **convenience** features for individuals (document vault, reminders, PDF) - **never** charging for access to benefits themselves.

For: seats, admin dashboards, integrations.

+ Scalable, investor-fundable. – Must avoid any "pay to access benefits" optics.

Path C - Nonprofit / grant-funded

Who pays: foundation grants, VA/state partnership contracts, corporate veteran-cause sponsorships, individual donations.

For: keeping it free and mission-locked.

+ Maximum trust; grant access. – Grant dependency; slower product velocity.

Recommended: a hybrid. Run mission-first (free to veterans) funded by **organization licenses (Path A) + grants/sponsorship (Path C)**, and add **optional premium convenience features (Path B)** later once trust is established. Decide together in Part 4.

Recommended pricing - organization licenses (veterans always free): Small (local VSO / nonprofit) **\$2,500/yr** · Mid (university / workforce board) **\$7,500/yr** · Enterprise (employer / state agency) **\$20,000/yr**. Give your first 1–2 partners a free or discounted pilot in exchange for feedback and a testimonial.

Recommended revenue model - Year 1 (lean start)

Recommended starting figures for a lean, bootstrapped first year. These are **estimates to validate** - not projections or guarantees. Put your own targets in the last column.

Revenue line	Recommended Year 1 (lean)	Your target
Organization licenses (VSOs, universities, employers)	~6 orgs across tiers ≈ \$45,000	\$ _____
Grants (veteran-focused foundation / VA / state)	1 grant ≈ \$50,000	\$ _____
Corporate sponsorship (veteran cause)	2 × \$10,000 ≈ \$20,000	\$ _____
Premium individual convenience features	Defer to Year 2 - \$0	\$ _____
Recommended Year-1 revenue target	≈ \$115,000	\$ _____

Recommended cost model - Year 1 (lean start)

Cost line	Recommended Year 1 (lean)	Your budget
Benefits data curation priority	~ \$20,000 (part-time researcher / VSO advisor)	\$ _____
Product / engineering	~ \$30,000 outsourced, or ~ \$0 if founder-built	\$ _____
Hosting & tools	~ \$2,000	\$ _____
Legal / compliance	~ \$5,000 (entity + disclaimer review)	\$ _____
People / part-time (partnerships, facilitation)	~ \$15,000	\$ _____
Recommended Year-1 cost (lean)	≈ \$72,000	\$ _____

~\$115k

Rec. Year-1 revenue

~\$72k

Rec. Year-1 cost (lean)

~\$43k

Rec. surplus to reinvest

If founder-built (engineering ≈ \$0), Year-1 cost drops to ~**\$42k**. The point of Year 1 isn't profit - it's funding accurate benefits data and one successful pilot before scaling. Adjust every number to your reality.

Money action items (next 90 days)

- ☐ Pick the lead path + hybrid mix (Part 4 decision).
- ☐ Draft a 1-page partner offer (what an org gets, at what price).
- ☐ Identify 5 target grants and 5 target org partners; note deadlines.
- ☐ Set a first-revenue goal (grant submitted or first license signed) and a date: _____
- ☐ Confirm nothing in the model charges veterans for benefits access or claims help.

Part 6 · Decisions, owners & action log

Capture what you decide today and who owns each next step.

Decisions made today

Topic	Decision	Why
Name		
Design direction		
Entity structure		
Lead monetization		
First state(s)		
Pilot partner		

Action items

Action	Owner	Due	Done

Open questions to resolve

Next working session

Date / time

Goal for next session

Always keep visible for veterans: Veterans Crisis Line - dial **988**, press **1** (or text 838255). Homeless Veterans: **1-877-424-3838**. Free accredited claims help: county veteran service officer or a VSO (VFW / American Legion / DAV).

VetPath is a planning & education tool - not the VA, a law firm, or an accredited claims representative. All benefit content is sample/demo data for this prototype and must be verified through official sources (VA.gov, your state Department of Veterans Affairs, accredited VSOs). All dollar figures are illustrative assumptions for planning only - not projections, advice, or guarantees. VetPath does not guarantee any benefit or eligibility.